decision-making loop—the defence minister preferring to use Bijji Kaul as the sole point of contact instead. Not surprising then, that compelling political pressure forced the deployment of the wrong troops at the wrong place at the wrong time.

4 Division was given the task of defending the entire McMahon Line, extending from Khenzemane near the Bhutan-Tibet-India tri-junction to Kibithu on the Burma border, a distance of more than 570 kilometres as the crow flies. There were no roads worth the name, and lateral communication was virtually impossible. There were no shelters and very little animal transport. Also, with winter setting in, there was actually no urgency to induct troops as the Chinese too would have retired to their secure bases north of the Himalayan watershed to wait out the winter.

As the QMG and the de facto man at the helm of affairs, Kaul was in his element. His job profile required that he be most intimately involved with the maintenance of the troops and all the associated logistical problems. During this time, typically, a meeting would be called with various officers assembled to put forward their demands. Regardless of who was in the chair, everyone would wait for the QMG to show up. When he arrived, Kaul would hardly acknowledge the other senior officers present. Whatever the requirement, he would announce that he could only provide a certain quantity and that was it. He would then look around and say that they would have to ‘make do’ with what he had said was possible and that he did not want any bellyaching from anyone. Finally, he would announce that he was late for another meeting (either with the prime minister or the defence minister) and would be gone. The chair, even if it was the CGS, would then smile and shrug his shoulders: ‘Well, gentlemen, you have heard the QMG; you can all go back and recast your plans accordingly. There is little more that I can do.’

As Kaul’s star continued to shine brightly, there were many who were quick to align themselves with him. The senior generals who advised caution and tried to speak up were scoffed at as being alarmist or lacking ‘fire in their belly’. Anybody who opposed the Menon-Kaul thought process or tried to speak up was earmarked for elimination.

4 Division had three brigades—of these, 5 Infantry Brigade was sent to Sikkim while its headquarters were to be in Darjeeling. That left 7 and 5 Infantry Brigades to be deployed in the whole of NEFA. The former was earmarked for deployment in the Kameng Frontier Division and its HQ was